

For sale



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"The amount of data being captured is so large that you have powerful machine learning systems crunching out behaviour patterns for better 'targeted advertising.'"

It seems I've spoken about Artificial Intelligence multiple times over the last couple of months and since we're going with AI as the theme, you're going to be reading a lot more about AI. So I'm going to do the hipster thing and not harp about AI at all. Instead we're going to be looking at something that's completely nefarious – digital ads. There were two separate incidents earlier this week, one involving Google and the other involving Microsoft. The weird thing was that both incidents happened within the same week.

It can be argued that both services have been subsidised by their respective companies in lieu of rights to slip in advertisements. However, these things are not explicitly made clear. Paying attention while setting up Windows 10 will bring about a few settings that mention whether you want to receive targeted advertising. Even if you disable that settings the OS still collects data. Which is why tools like Spybot Anti-Beacon exist that can put an end to all of Microsoft's telemetry services. Since Windows 10 is a really popular OS, users can tear it apart and put an end any untoward service. On the other hand, Google Home isn't, so we're yet to see a thriving ecosystem of custom ROMs like we have for Android smartphones. And when that happens, these unwanted advertisements will go away if you undertake the effort of loading a custom ROM.

So what's the downside? Well, like Mr. James Comey, Director of FBI said earlier this month, absolute privacy does not exist in the US. And that's a country with strict privacy laws. We on the other hand, have a huge mobile-first population who don't even understand what privacy is, let alone the ramifications of having their personal data out there for sale. All of this is set to get worse in the coming years, the new FCC Chairman is a godsend for all of these ad serving companies as he just halted new privacy protection laws in the US. The matter is still being discussed so we don't know what the outcome will be but going by how Mr. Pai has maintained a very pro-industry, anti-privacy and anti-consumer stance throughout his stint at the FCC. And we don't see things turning out for the better for consumers.

To an extent, it is fine if the information that companies store about you is used just

to serve you ads. Unfortunately, that's not the case. Your information is up for sale to whomsoever can come up with the moolah. And with privacy laws to take a beating in the near future, even more companies are going to zero-in on this new opportunity. This is where AI comes into the picture. Or if you keep up with the happenings, it already has. The amount of data being captured is so large that you have powerful machine learning systems crunching out behaviour patterns for better "targeted advertising." It's not just these patterns that are up for sale but even the raw data. So let's recap, we have always-on devices capturing data about you and your family which is used to generate ~~tera~~ petabytes of metadata. Which in turn is up for sale. Now imagine the government getting their hands on that data. Now imagine the very same government with a very extremist outlook. And now, go and read 1984.

This is the kind of stuff that dystopian novels are made of and it's happening really fast. Countries with weak IT Laws are even more susceptible. We're one of them. Companies operating in India can get away with a lot because of our poor laws. Take for example the McDonald's security lapse which put the private data of 2.2 million Indians out in the open thanks to an open API endpoint. The company not only denied the issue but hasn't resolved the issue for over a week and we're yet to hear from any Government agencies about it.

What we need is a strong legal framework for IT laws which is in line with developments in the technology sector and that's a tall order. Especially since the people are in the dark about how bad things can turn out if no action is taken and going by how laws are influenced by vote bank politics in India, it's high time we techies got together to form a large enough vote bank. I'm thinking of Technical People's Party or TPP for short ... wait, that didn't come out right. 

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